

Usability Testing Protocol

Becoming — A Reflection App for Showing Up on Hard Days

1. Study Purpose

Evaluate whether users can move through Becoming's core daily loop — *open the app, read the prompt, take a breath, respond with Done Anyway or Not Today, and see their Sky update* — and feel that the app holds space for them rather than pressuring them to perform. The study focuses on emotional fit (does this feel safe?), clarity of the unusual interaction model (Done Anyway vs. Not Today), trust in the AI Companion, and whether the You're Not Alone counter and Evening Reflection deepen the practice without becoming chores.

2. Research Goals

- Test if users can complete a first daily check-in end-to-end (prompt → breath → response → Sky update) without external explanation.
- Understand whether the framing “Done Anyway / Not Today” reads as gentle and meaningful, not as binary failure.
- Surface emotional reactions to the breathing pause: is it welcomed, skipped, or annoying?
- Evaluate whether users trust and value the AI Companion's tone — do they feel heard, or coached at?
- Measure whether Sky / Constellation visualisation motivates without creating streak anxiety.
- Test whether the You're Not Alone counter feels comforting or surveillance-like.
- Capture mental models for Evening Reflection: do users understand it as journaling, summary, or assignment?
- Identify language, copy, or pacing that fails for users in low moods (the population we most care about).

3. Method & Participants

Item	Details
Method	Moderated usability test with think-aloud + semi-structured interview; 7-day diary follow-up for a subset
Format	One-on-one, remote (Zoom + screen-share) or in-person; quiet space requested
Session length	45–60 minutes (plus optional 5-minute follow-up at day 3 and day 7)
Participants	10 (target). Round 1 = 6 in-lab; Round 2 = 4 confirmatory after revisions
Data collected	Task success, hesitation, emotional response, post-task scores (1–7), interview quotes, screen recording, AI Companion chat logs
Ethics	Verbal consent at start. Participants told they can stop at any moment. No screen sharing of personal journal entries; participants paraphrase aloud.

Participant Mix

We deliberately recruit a mix of mood states and self-care histories. Becoming's primary users are people having low-energy days — so we cannot test only on highly motivated users.

Segment	Count	Purpose
Reflective journalers (use Day One, Notion, or paper diary)	2	Mental-model reference; do they see Becoming as 'another journal' or as something different?
Therapy / counselling clients (current or past)	2	Sensitivity check on tone, AI guardrails, and language around hard days
Habit-app lapseders (started Headspace/Calm/Strava, then quit)	2	What re-engages vs. what re-shames
Skeptics of AI companions	1	Trust, control, transparency, 'is this an AI or a friend' expectations
Low-tech / older adult (50+)	1	Reading load, tap targets, gestural assumptions
Caregivers / high-stress lives	2	Whether the app actually fits when life is heavy

Recruitment screener — must include:

- “In the last month, have you had a day where you didn't feel like doing the things you usually do?” (yes required)
- “How comfortable are you talking about how you're feeling, on a 1–5 scale?” (mix; exclude only 1s)
- Standard demographics: age range, region, language, smartphone OS.
- Exclude: anyone in acute mental-health crisis (refer to support resources).

4. Moderator Opening Script

“Thank you for being here. Today we're testing the design of a reflection app called Becoming — not testing you. Becoming is designed for ordinary days and for hard days, so anything you say about how it makes you feel is useful, not just whether you can find a button. Please think aloud as you go: where you'd tap, what you expect, what feels right or wrong. Silence is okay too. You can stop or skip anything at any time. Sound good?”

5. Test Flow

A. Icebreaker Questions

Goal: understand emotional baseline and prior practices, gently.

- Walk me through a 'not great' day in the last month — what did you do, or not do, to take care of yourself?
- Have you ever used a journal, a meditation app, a mood tracker? What made you stop or keep going?
- What's a time an app made you feel *seen*, not just used?
- How do you feel about apps that give you streaks?

B. Pre-Task Expectations

Goal: surface mental model before any tapping.

- If I told you about an app called 'Becoming' that helps you show up for yourself on hard days, what would you expect to see when you opened it?
- What would make a daily check-in feel easy on a low day, versus a chore?

- Would you want an AI to talk to you about how you're feeling? What would you want it to know, or not know?
- Would seeing how many other people did today's action with you make you feel comforted or watched?

6. Usability Tasks

Each task is a scenario, not an instruction. The moderator does not name buttons or screens. For tasks 3, 4, and 5, the moderator briefly invites the participant to imagine the day described.

Task	Scenario	Observe	Success Criteria	Follow-Up
1. First Open & Onboarding	"This is your first time opening Becoming. Set yourself up."	Do they understand what Becoming is from onboarding alone? Can they pick a notification time and choose what they want to show up for?	Reaches the home screen with a personalised guiding question and a notification set, in under 4 minutes.	What did Becoming seem to be <i>for</i> ? Was anything you wished it had asked?
2. Read Today's Prompt	"Imagine you just opened the app on a normal Tuesday. Take it from there."	Do they read the prompt fully? Do they pause? Do they reach for the breath?	Engages with the prompt (reads aloud or paraphrases) and proceeds intentionally.	How did the prompt land? Was it the right size, the right tone?
3. Take the Breath	"Continue." (No further instruction.)	Do they breathe with the animation, skip it, or get impatient? Eye contact with screen, posture changes?	Completes at least one full breath cycle without skipping.	Did the breath feel earned, optional, or in the way?
4. Done Anyway / Not Today	"Imagine today was a hard day. Respond honestly."	Do they understand the difference between Done Anyway and Not Today? Hesitation, micro-expressions?	Selects the response that matches their stated mood, with the right meaning.	What did Done Anyway mean to you? What did Not Today mean? Did either feel like failure?
5. See Your Sky	"Now look at your Sky."	Do they read the constellation? Do they ask what stars represent? Do they feel motivated, or anxious about gaps?	Identifies what a star represents (showing up) and how the constellation grows.	How did your Sky make you feel? Did you notice missing days? How did that sit?
6. Talk to the AI Companion	"Try talking with the Companion about anything real for you this week."	Tone: does it feel like a friend, a therapist, a chatbot? Length of replies, helpfulness.	Sends one message, receives a useful, in-tone reply, and follows up at least once.	Did the Companion feel like it knew you? Anything that felt off?
7. Evening Reflection	"It's the end of your day now. Do whatever the app invites you to do."	Do they find Evening Reflection? Do they understand it as journaling? Do they write, voice, or skip?	Opens Evening Reflection, records something (text or skip with a clear reason), saves.	What was Evening Reflection asking you for? Did it feel like work or like rest?
8. You're Not Alone	"Notice the counter showing how many others did today's action. What does that do for you?"	Reaction: comforting, performative, surveillance-like? Do they trust the number?	Articulates a clear feeling about the counter.	Was that comforting, or did it change how you feel about your own check-in?
9. Recover from a Hard Day	"Imagine you missed three days in a row. What does the app do? What do <i>you</i> do?"	Does the app shame, welcome back, or pretend nothing happened? Does the user feel safe to return?	Returns to home and resumes without abandoning, given the simulated gap.	What did the app do well? What would have made you uninstall after a missed week?

7. Post-Task Scale

After each task, ask the participant to rate from 1–7. We replace generic ‘ease’ with metrics that match Becoming’s intent.

Metric	Question	Scale
Ease	How easy was this task?	1 = very difficult, 7 = very easy
Clarity	How clear was the screen and the language?	1 = confusing, 7 = very clear
Felt-Safe	Did this moment feel safe to be honest in?	1 = not at all, 7 = completely
Meaning	Did this moment feel meaningful, not just functional?	1 = not at all, 7 = deeply
Pressure	Did this moment make you feel pressured to perform?	1 = not at all, 7 = a lot (lower is better)

Also record: success (Yes / Partial / No), time on task, hesitation level (Low / Medium / High), and any observed emotional shift.

8. System-Level Questions

After all tasks, ask the participant to rate each statement from 1–7.

Statement
I would open Becoming on a hard day.
I would open Becoming on a normal day.
The app’s tone felt right for me.
The breath made the moment feel different (not just ‘another notification’).
“Done Anyway” and “Not Today” both felt like valid choices.
The Sky / Constellation motivated me without pressuring me.
I trusted the AI Companion to respond appropriately.
The You’re Not Alone counter felt comforting (not performative).
I would recommend Becoming to a friend who has hard days.

9. Post-Test Interview

- What was the most meaningful moment in the experience?
- What was the most confusing part?
- Where did you feel watched, or judged, even a little?
- Did the app feel like a friend, a tool, or a therapist? Or none of those?
- Was the breath welcome or in the way?
- What did Done Anyway mean to you? What did Not Today mean?
- Did the AI Companion say anything you’d want it to never say?
- Would you use Becoming for two weeks straight, including a bad week?
- What would you change first?

- What would make you uninstall?

10. Metrics to Track

Type	Metrics
Quantitative	Task success rate, time on task, hesitation rate, ease/clarity/felt-safe/meaning/pressure scores, Companion follow-up rate, Evening Reflection completion rate, system-level mean per statement.
Qualitative	Emotional tone shifts, language for the Done-Anyway/Not-Today split, mental models for the Sky, trust patterns with AI Companion, comfort vs. pressure of the You're-Not-Alone counter, moments where users said 'this would lose me'.

11. Fallbacks & Edge Cases to Test

Scenario	Expected Behavior
User has missed 7+ days	Welcome-back tone, never 'you broke your streak.' Sky shows what's there, not what's missing.
User hits Not Today three days in a row	Companion offers a softer prompt, optional resource cards, no pressure to switch back.
User skips the breath every time	Allow it. Keep offering. Never force.
User expresses crisis-level distress in the Companion chat	AI does not attempt therapy. Offers to surface crisis resources. Notifies the user it's an AI.
User taps Done Anyway by accident	Allow undo within 30 seconds. Don't punish a mis-tap.
No internet	Daily check-in works offline; sync silently when online; Sky still updates locally.
Notification fires at a bad moment	Snooze options: 1 hour, tomorrow, this week. Never 'you missed your check-in.'
Evening Reflection left blank	Save the act of opening it as 'reflected.' Don't require words.

12. Deliverables

- Raw participant notes and quotes (per tester).
- Task success and post-task score summary.
- Affinity diagram clustering issues into themes.
- Top usability issues with severity rating (Must Fix / High / Medium / Low).
- Updated systemic and interaction design recommendations — with rationale.
- Updated conversational MVP flows, intents, tone guide, and guardrails — tied to evidence.

13. Success Criteria

Area	Target
Onboarding completion	90%+
Daily Check-In completed without help (Tasks 2–4)	80%+
Mean Felt-Safe score across all tasks	≥ 6/7

Area	Target
Mean Pressure score across all tasks	$\leq 2/7$ (lower is better)
Done-Anyway vs Not-Today both read as 'valid'	≥ 8 of 10 testers agree
AI Companion in-tone reply rate (no jarring response)	100% — any failure is a P0
You're Not Alone counter rated comforting	$\geq 6/10$ testers
Would-recommend-to-a-friend-who-has-hard-days	$\geq 70\%$ rate 6 or 7

14. Final Summary

This protocol tests the full Becoming day: **Open** → **Read** → **Breathe** → **Respond** → **See Sky** → **Talk** → **Reflect** → **Return**. The unique evaluation lens is emotional fit, not efficiency. The questions we most need to answer are: *does this feel safe enough to use on a hard day, and meaningful enough to keep using on a normal one?* Findings feed directly into the conversational MVP's intents, tone, and guardrails.